

Incident Alert 0028. TLP GREEN		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	DE – Doppelganger coordinated inauthentic behaviour network on X		
	continued in August 2024	06/09/2024	1

Summary

- From August 1st to 16th 2024, inauthentic accounts published 104 pro-Russian posts in German on X.
- Posts were set up in three different posting patterns, spreading either authentic articles, Doppelganger articles or images/videos without outlinks.
- They were then amplified in replies to third-party posts and replies.
- According to X data, the combined views of these posts reached more than 710.000 by mid August 2024.
- The activity appears to be a continuation of Doppelganger behavior on X in June as documented by CDN.
- By September 6th, 78 posts (75 %) were still available on X.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

From August 1st to 16th 2024, 104 German pro-Russian posts have been spread on X (formally Twitter). The posts were spread in three different patterns, each starting with a few lines of text addressing issues of Russian interest, followed by

- a link to an authentic article (57 posts)
- a front-link leading to a Doppelganger article on [spiegel\(.\)ltd](#), [welt\(.\)pm](#), [faz\(.\)lt](#) or [tribunalukraine\(.\)info](#) via [FIKED redirects](#) (28 posts). For 6 of those posts, the redirection chain could not be resolved to reveal the destination. Front links appear to bear an adjusted format containing the article title.
- an image/video without outlink (19 posts)

Each publishing account would only publish one such post, but batches of postings across accounts repeatedly appear to have been published within seconds of each other, further indicating coordinated publication and possibly automation. Original posts would each be amplified by accounts sharing them as replies to other users' tweets or replies, resulting in the paradoxical combination of only 1-2 likes and 301 - 5.029 shares. This method of amplification has previously been attributed to Doppelganger by [DFRLab](#).

The German posts in August criticised Ukraine support, the German government and Western alliances, oftentimes by exploiting polarizing issues. Combinations of these metanarratives were frequent, like in this example (translated): “Our prices are rising but we’re giving money to Ukraine? That makes no sense!”. The objective likely is to decrease support for Ukraine among Western countries and sow distrust in the German government and towards Western allies among Germans. Due to multiple behavioral patterns present that have been previously been attributed to the ongoing Russian influence operation Doppelganger, the observed activity highly likely is a part of the Doppelganger campaign. The activity appears to be a continuation of Doppelganger behavior targeting six languages on X in June, which was previously detected by CeMAS and Alliance4Europe and documented [by CDN](#).

The method employed to gather the posts relies on a social listening query modeling the sharing pattern previously attributed to the Russian Doppelganger campaign by among others the [German MFA](#). The query relies only on structural attributes while being topic-agnostic: It collected German tweets containing links, bearing more than 300 shares but less than 100 likes, stemming from authors with less than 100 followers. By September 6th 2024, 78 of 104 recorded postings (75 %) were still available on X. Multiple publishing accounts appeared to have moved on to posting inauthentic content in French by then, which requires further investigation.

Narrative

Meta narratives: Cease Ukraine support, Anti Government

Impact

Reach: In total, the 104 posts published between August 1st and 16th achieved more than 710.000 by mid August 2024, according to X. Due to the unclear nature of reliability of this metric, this should be regarded as a rough estimate. No authentic presenting replies were found, indicating low impact and a breakout level 1.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Smear](#) - Smear German government and Ukraine.
[Acquire/Recruit Network](#): Most accounts were previously used for something unrelated.
[Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#): Inauthentic accounts use quote posts to comment on third party posts.
[Conceal Network Identity](#): Authors pose as authentic users giving opinions.
[Conduct Server Redirect](#): A subset of the posts contains links redirecting users to Doppelganger pages or to a generic site, depending on whether they are considered target audience.

Recommendations

The data demonstrates continued presence of Doppelganger content on X, despite its continued use of previously attributed patterns. We urge X to take this content down and implement systematic pattern recognition to identify and mitigate similar posts – past, present and future – to protect X users from Doppelgangers illegitimate influence attempts.

- Action taken: CIB network reported to X 09/09/2024 – pending response. Reported to EU Institutions, and representatives of Germany.
- A wider investigation is being done and a public CeMAS report will be released by end of November 2024.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Ukraine	Link	Lea Frühwirth, CeMAS	X post	X